

Report slams EU auto policy as 'misguided'

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【要点】

- ・ EUの自動車産業保護政策は「誤った方針」であり、排出基準の緩和や中国製EVへの関税、地域内容要件などの施策は効果的ではないとBruegel智口が批判している。
- ・ EUは中国からのハイブリッド車の流入に対して新たな関税を即座に導入するのではなく、北京との交渉を進めるべきであり、既存の「持続可能性と強靱性基準」を適用すべきだと提言されている。
- ・ 自動車産業の売上が2019年以來回復していないため、失業や工場閉鎖が相次ぎ、労働者による抗議が発生している。
- ・ 中国製EVの関税導入後、中国メーカーは関税対象外のプラグインハイブリッドへシフトしており、新たな問題が生じている。
- ・ 中国製電動車の輸入急増の一方で、欧米ブランドも中国での製造コストの低さを理由に中国で生産した車をEUに輸入している。

【メール原文】

Navigating the complex world of EU mobility policy and infrastructure. By JORDYN DAHL with MARTINA SAPIO SNEAK PEEK — A new report argues that the EU'

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By JORDYN DAHL

with MARTINA SAPIO

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SNEAK PEEK

— A new report argues that the EU's attempts to shield the automotive sector from competition aren't working.

— Europe's rail sector needs faster standardization to defend its global lead, as Brussels pushes for a more unified rail market.

— The EPP is divided over what countries should be included or left out of the Industrial Accelerator Act.

Good morning, and welcome to Morning Mobility.

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DRIVING THE DAY

REPORT SLAMS EU EFFORTS TO PROTECT CARMAKERS: The European Commission is scrambling to protect an automotive sector that's responsible for 13.8 million direct and indirect jobs across the bloc. Its attempts have included easing emission targets for automakers, slapping new duties on made-in-China EVs and proposing local content requirements for cars. "This approach is misguided," according to a blistering analysis from the Bruegel think tank that's out today and was seen in advance by POLITICO.

All wrong: The think tank calls for Brussels to negotiate with Beijing over the flood of Chinese hybrids coming into the bloc rather than immediately imposing new tariffs — as some carmakers and officials are demanding. The Industrial Accelerator Act won't save the car industry, and the EU should instead apply existing "sustainability and resilience criteria." And efforts to slow the EV transition to save carmakers would be self-defeating, the report warns.

Scale of the problem: Car sales dropped in the pandemic and have never returned to their 2019 levels. The sector is bleeding jobs and is at loggerheads with workers, who took to the streets on Monday to protest large-scale layoffs and factory closures. German luxury brand Mercedes-Benz confirmed to POLITICO's sister publication WELT on Monday that it could close two plants.

Economic hit: Vehicle exports, meanwhile, have fallen after peaking in 2023 as global demand shifts toward electric cars. The fall in exports coincides with a surge of vehicles imported from China.

Not just the Chinese: While the focus is on imports from Chinese automakers, European brands are also producing vehicles in China where costs are lower and then shipping them to the EU. Chinese-built electric vehicles made up 20% of total EV sales in 2026, but more than half of those were Western-branded cars made in China, Bruegel's report finds.

Hybrid threat: After the European Commission slapped new duties on made-in-China EVs, imports tapered off as Chinese automakers shifted toward plug-in hybrids, which aren't subject to the new duties. Now carmakers and some policymakers want to EU to stem the hybrid surge. Instead, the EU should "pursue a negotiated agreement" with China that would set a quota on the number of imported hybrids. Only if negotiations fail should temporary safeguards be introduced, Bruegel argues. "The goal should not be to prevent competition with the Chinese, but provide European producers time to catch up."

Forget local content: The Industrial Accelerator Act would set Made in Europe requirements for cars that are included in public subsidy schemes or purchased through public procurement. But the report's authors say enacting Buy European requirements for components or vehicles won't be effective.

The future is electric: The Commission did away with its de facto 2035 combustion engine ban in last year's automotive package. The Bruegel report calls discussions on slowing the EV transition "an unhelpful distraction," arguing that moving targets will slow down charging infrastructure rollout and investor-led initiatives.

RAIL

EUROPE'S RAIL CHIEF SAYS STANDARDIZE OR LOSE GROUND: Europe needs to turn its fragmented rail market into a genuine single market if it wants to preserve its global industrial lead, Giorgio Travaini of Europe's Rail Joint Undertaking told Martina, arguing that common technical solutions and interfaces are now central to the sector's competitiveness.

Reminder: Europe's Rail Joint Undertaking is the EU-industry body that brings the European Commission together with rail manufacturers, operators, infrastructure managers and research partners to develop and demonstrate common rail technologies. Its job is to turn research into interoperable solutions that can be deployed across Europe — including work on ERTMS, signaling, automation, digitalization and system architecture — rather than leaving each country or company to develop its own approach.

The China comparison: Travaini said Europe's rail industry remains highly competitive but is under growing pressure from Asia. The problem, he argued, is that European companies still design too many solutions for individual national markets. "What is necessary is to work together and create that single European market," he said.

Less variety: The challenge, he said, is making common solutions work on Europe's existing and highly heterogeneous railway system. Technologies proven in one country — whether signaling equipment or solutions for extreme weather — cannot always simply be copied elsewhere because trains and infrastructure differ. But adapting them country-by-country also has a cost: "If you create 10,000 versions, then your railway system costs you 10 times more."

Resilience joins the agenda: Travaini also said rail research increasingly has to address geopolitical crises, cybersecurity and climate extremes to ensure that trains and infrastructure remain available during disruptions. That requires not only new technology but decisions on where investment has the greatest impact, as well as coordination with bodies ranging from infrastructure managers to law-enforcement authorities.

Next budget fight: The Rail Joint Undertaking is not guaranteed beyond the current EU budget cycle. Travaini said the Commission and member countries are considering what partnerships should continue under the next framework, with Brussels looking to reduce their overall number. Europe's rail sector has made the case for renewal, he said, but the decision will ultimately be political.

His pitch: Travaini argued rail has a particularly strong claim because it is one of the few transport industries where Europe still holds a global lead — while also contributing to decarbonization. "The arguments for renewing it are there," he said. "We have put them on the table."

EU PARLIAMENT HEADS TO GREECE TO PROBE CRASH: A European Parliament delegation is visiting Greece this week to assess measures implemented since Greece's deadliest train disaster in 2023 in Tempe, which killed 57 people. The fact-finding mission will be led by Dolores Montserrat, vice chair of the Parliament's Committee on Petitions, our colleague Nektaria Stamouli reports.

What they're looking for: MEPs will examine railway safety, along with how EU legislation has been implemented and progress on EU-funded rail infrastructure projects. The group will present its findings at a news conference on Wednesday.

Catch up: The deadly head-on collision occurred when a freight train and a passenger train were allowed on the same rail line. The crash raised questions about governance in Greece, as Athens had not updated its rail network to meet EU requirements when the crash happened and the state rail company was accused of mismanagement.

POLISH TRAIN DRIVERS KEEP PRESSURE ON SAFETY: Poland's train drivers' union says their nationwide slowdown earlier this month was caused by years of frustration over repeated level-crossing accidents and what it sees as a failure by authorities to tackle the problem systematically — not simply a reaction to one deadly crash.

The numbers: Daniel Biernacik, vice president of the Train Drivers' Trade Union in Poland, told Martina the union counted roughly 140 incidents in 2024, around 180 in 2025 and about 130 so far this year. Many incidents follow a very similar pattern, he said: A vehicle enters a crossing despite warning signals or barriers, becomes trapped on the tracks or otherwise creates an obstacle that the approaching train cannot avoid.

The wider system: The union wants a broader review of the way crossings are protected, including signaling, monitoring, obstacle-detection systems and measures to prevent vehicles becoming trapped between barriers. The union also wants stronger procedures for reporting and responding to known safety risks, arguing that there have been cases where railway employees flagged dangerous infrastructure or operating conditions but those warnings were not treated with enough urgency.

Years of warnings: Biernacik said the union had raised these concerns repeatedly through public safety campaigns, demonstrations outside the infrastructure ministry, petitions and meetings with government and railway authorities, including discussions at a special railway sector commission. Biernacik said the latest protest reflected "accumulated frustration."

Government response: Following the latest protest and the Sokolniki Suche crash, he added, Infrastructure Minister Dariusz Klimczak told the union that urgent work would begin on legislative and technical measures to improve railway safety, including at level crossings. He also announced work on legislation covering train drivers' working time.

CARS

EPP WANTS MORE TIME ON IAA AMENDMENTS: The three co-leads on the Industrial Accelerator Act started discussions on their recently published draft report. MEPs have until Sept. 30 to submit amendments, but the European People's Party has requested that date be pushed back, a person familiar with the matter told our colleague Francesca Micheletti. The new date is yet to be agreed.

EPP preparations: It's no wonder that the EPP needs more time. Delegates from the largest political family in parliament are having a hard time finding common ground, particularly on "Made in Europe." Divisions are particularly deep between Germany and Spain, with national interests playing into the discussion. Francesca and Jordyn have more here .

PIT STOPS

U.K. Prime Minister Andy Burnham declined to back the head of the country's air traffic controllers after a massive blackout led to flight cancellations.

Headlines

Here's a recap of yesterday's news, along with Pro articles and alerts from overnight.

European center right splits over 'Made in Europe'

Spanish and German lawmakers from the European People's Party are at odds over the Industrial Accelerator Act.

By Francesca Micheletti, Jordyn Dahl · Sept 21, 2026, 06:01 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

Document: EU countries consider tougher rules on carbon allowance reserves

By Ben Makuch · Sept 21, 2026, 05:08 pm Europe/Brussels CEST

11 countries push for pause on new EU laws

"We can't go on tabling new legislative proposals when existing rules have not been fully implemented," says Austria's Europe minister.

By Nicholas Vinocur · Sept 21, 2026, 11:16 am Europe/Brussels CEST

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